Fire Dance

By Will Scheffer

An African-American man enters in a conservative business suit. He addresses the audience. He speaks very quickly. Throughout he changes from his male drag into her full and divine female drag -- makeup, pumps, wig and all. The transformation is efficient, rhythmic, and astonishing.

CRYSTAL: Before I went on Prozac . . . I used to be a very emotional person, hyper-sensitive you know, hysterical - and just forget about self-esteem. This used to make things hard for me, you know, like it would make it hard for me sometimes, to live in this world, to do the things that people need to do to - you know - live. For instance, like to go to the grocery store, or to mail a letter, you know, NORMAL things. I didn't even used to be able to go to the bank even, to stand on that line, to talk to the teller, it would get me - agitated. *(He begins to remove suit.)*

Now, I didn't think that this was always so bad of a thing though, at that particular time in my life - because what I was . . . **was** - what I was - I was a creative person, you know, a performer. Uh-huhhh! I used to do shows at The Anvil and The Mineshaft - you remember those places, yes? Perhaps then you have even heard of me - Crystal was my name, Crystal Chandaliah - *(He waits for recognition.)*

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INTRODUCTION

Drag is a celebration. Drag is an attitude. Today's drag queen is often a gay man who has embraced that part of himself that, as a child, was considered shameful and undeserving. Rather than allowing himself to be bullied, he has revealed that hidden aspect of himself, dressed her up, made her fabulous and invincible. He has found strength in her and wears her like a shield. Drag is some of the best parts of who he is, magnified and impervious. Today's drag queen is at home in a gay bar, a pride parade or an AIDS charity event. Her audience is comprised of individuals who want to rejoice in difference, to celebrate a shared triumph over prejudice and

misunderstanding, to find strength in community. So when Crystal's mentor dies in a freak accident, she struggles to remain invincible . . . impervious. Fire Dance by Will Scheffer

CRYSTAL: Yes, well - in my time, did I ever light up a stage - oh yes honey, I was electric. Fabulous. FLAMING! *(Lights pop on at makeup table.)*

You see, before I went on Prozac, I was the partner of The Amazing Nubia - now you MUST remember HER - She did the Fire Dance at The Anvil: the most famous act since Carmen Miranda, the Salem Witch Trials, and Cher all rolled into one.

Oh yes - Nubia taught me everything I know about show business, she was like a sister to me; and her and me, we were like the hottest sister act in town. *(Puts on his makeup robe.)*

You COULD say that Nubia discovered me and you wouldn't be lying. She discovered me one night in 1975, lying on the floor of the bathroom, with my wrists slit open and my dress slashed to pieces. What a mess, darling - bleeding all over that linoleum! Now what Nubia DID - what she did was . . . this is what she did: she ripped off her gold lame sash, tied it around my arms and stopped off the bleeding! Next day I woke up in her cold-water apartment on Christopher Street, Donna Summers was singing on the radio, and Nubia fed me on rose hips tea. She called herself Miss Nurse ... and for two weeks she didn't get out of her stunning white nursing ensemble with matching white pumps. She saved my life! And she taught me how to Fire Dance. She said: "Honey, if you gotta burn - make 'em pay to see it." *(Begins to put on makeup.)*

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Nubia was the mother of all drag queens. They don't make 'em like that anymore. She was the first queen to throw a bottle at the cops during the Stonewall Rebellion. Other queens invented the word, FIERCE, just to describe her. It has even been rumored that Nubia was the first homosexual ever to snap her fingers *(She snaps.)* and the phrase: "I will read your beads, Miss Mary Dugan!" has been attributed to her. *(He does his eyes, rouge and cheekbones.)*

Nubia taught me that to do the Fire Dance you gotta have a . . . VENEER, you know what I'm talking about? One day she says to me: "Honey - honey - you best be gettin' yourself some VENEER! else you gonna wind up on that bathroom floor again!" "VENEER?" I says to her. "VENEER," she says, "like you know, like a . . . like a SHEEN, you see, 'cause let me tell you something, Miss Thing Girl: It ain't easy doin' the Fire Dance, bein' a drag queen, livin' the life. Uh-uh - No, darlin'." And Nubia was right. *(Lipwork.)*

It seems these days everybody and her mother wants to be a drag queen, how funny you know, when all I ever wanted was just to be a NORMAL person, like y'all. I mean sure it may LOOK glamorous, but it's an awful lot of work to make yourself over! I mean let all the other queens sing "I AM WHAT I AM," but drag queens we sing "I AM WHAT I AM NOT," you know what I'm sayin'? *(Powder and final touches.)*

Uh-uh. Tsk tsk tsk: I even hear that Mr. Patrick Swayze is dressin' himself up for some big Hollywood type movie about drag queens - well I got some advice for you Mr. Patrick Swayze honey: You best be doin' some serious research, girlfriend! *(Final lip outline - gets into stockings, breasts, dress.)* Oh yes. Nubia

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taught me how to have a fierce veneer.

Sometimes we danced the Fire Dance five or six times a night. Twirling our fiery batons to Pearl Bailey's rendition of "Hot Voodoo," lip synching to Martha and the Vandella's cover of "Heatwave," glittering in our sequined dresses, our amazing black bodies shimmering under the virgin olive oil that we had so carefully applied before the show to protect us from the heat. But to tell you the truth, underneath my veneer - I still dreamed of a normal life - like married to some nice blonde Republican, like George Bush's nephew . . . a life in which I went to the bank without fear, in which I balanced my check-book, a life in which I cooked my man dinner and cleaned his kitchen, but Nubia said: "You're crazy girl! Don't even think such thoughts. That life ain't never gonna be for you. But you know, the real fact is, I loved Nubia. Not in a sexy way. But I really loved her. More than the guys from Greenpoint in the back seats of their white Continentals. The guys who I couldn't stop loving even though they used to beat me up after, more than them, more than myself even, I loved her.

And I loved the Fire Dance, the life of dancin' the Fire Dance with abandon, unafraid. *(Lights shift.) – Sing portions of * Heatwave while performing with fire batons)*

Then one night in the middle of a performance I looked on as suddenly, Nubia's amazing black body was consumed by flames. A freak accident. Her skin blazing like some highly flammable material, which no one could put out, no matter how we tried. Sometimes I see her face looking up at me, as it did at that moment, and I swear it was like she was almost smiling through the pain.

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The crowd was going crazy around us, screaming and wailing, but I felt almost calm as I looked into Nubia's smiling face, as if she was saying to me what she had said a hundred thousand times to me before: "Crystal, if you do the Fire Dance, you gotta be prepared to burn." *(Finishing touches on costume, boa, jewels.)*

Next day I went to a Chemical Bank and I opened a checking account. I went to a Dr. Casey, a very nice man, who put me on Prozac. That was five years ago and I've never looked back. Today, I am a normal person. A happy person. I really, really am! I work as a word processor in a small law firm. I live with my boyfriend in New Jersey. He's a chemical engineer at Hoffman-La Roche Labs and he gets me my Prozac for free.

Nowadays my life is good! On Saturdays I shop at ShopRite. On Sundays I iron my shirt to get ready for work. And I balance my checkbook once a week! *(Wig, and then finished, a vision, she presents herself to the crowd.)*

I don't dance the Fire Dance anymore. Sometimes when I go to the city, I'll run into one of the girls on the street, and they'll ask me if I don't miss performing. I tell then no, and it's true: I don't miss the Fire Dance. But sometimes late at night, around two in the morning, when my night shift's done and I can't sleep, I sneak into the bathroom. I close the door and I light many candles - *(Lights candles, spotlight focuses on her.)* - and I stare at my face in the mirror . . . And as I stare into the flames of the candles flickering around me I begin to sing, I sing in my own voice. I sing for Nubia, for all the girls, for myself I sing, this is what I tell us *(Smoke blows around her as she sings a song like * Aretha Franklin's, "I Say a Little Prayer . . . " Lights fade.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Will Scheffer
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AWARD HISTORY

2012 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier

****NOTE: The song "Heatwave" by*** Martha and the Vandellas can be reviewed at
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XE2fnYpwrnq

****NOTE: The song "I Say a Little Prayer" by Aretha Franklin can be reviewed at***
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KtBbyglq37E

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